Who Gets Drafted?

What the draft rewards in D1 players: performance against everyone, the competition, tools, and the paths that look like shortcuts

Trent Reimers | NCAA D1 2023-2026 | October 26, 2026

The question. Which college performance gets a D1 player drafted, and do the paths players take on the way (transferring up a conference, having been drafted out of high school) change their odds?

The short answer. Scouts draft tools and production measured against all of D1. Conference strength matters because it says how good the competition was. Once a player's draft-year numbers, tool and conference are known, neither moving up nor a high-school draft pedigree adds a clear boost: both mostly mark players who were already better.

Key findings

1. **The yardstick is all of D1, not the conference.** Nearly every stat tracks the draft better ranked against all of D1 than against the player's own conference. The same conference percentile is worth far more in a strong conference: a 75th-percentile player in a strong conference is drafted more often than a 95th-percentile player in a weak one.
2. **Velocity leads for pitchers; production leads for hitters.** Fastball velocity is the single strongest predictor for pitchers (Spearman 0.46). For hitters, opponent-adjusted run value against D1 leads (0.37) and EV90 adds to it (0.27). In-zone whiff adds the most of the approach stats once the tools are combined, and zone rate adds some for pitchers; chase, pull-air and soft contact add little.
3. **Together they sort the draft well.** Performance, conference strength and one tool separate drafted from undrafted players with a cross-validated AUC of 0.92 for pitchers and 0.88 for hitters, and lose nothing on a draft they never saw (0.93 and 0.90 on 2026, fit on 2023-2025 only). The player finder is a sound screen: it does about as well as a plain run-value cut that flags the same share of players.
4. **Moving up isn't a shortcut.** At the same draft-year numbers, hitters who moved up for the draft year were drafted less often and pitchers no differently. Pitchers who moved up were drafted more often than their prior season predicts, most likely because programs recruit the pitchers whose stuff scouts already like (and this rests on the quarter of moves TrackMan saw); among those who actually got worse, the edge is no longer clear.
5. **Neither is a high-school draft pedigree.** 58% of pitchers and 51% of hitters who were high-school picks were drafted as juniors, against 20% and 17% of everyone else, but they are better players in stronger programs. At equal performance and tool, the odds ratio (1.2× for pitchers, 1.4× for hitters) is not distinguishable from 1.

Data: 11,381 draft-eligible D1 player-seasons, 2023-2026 (1,385 drafted), TrackMan pitch data, every MLB pick 2015-2026, and every D1 roster 2021-2026. Data and methods are in the appendix.

PART 1

The yardstick: performance against all of D1

Before asking what scouts reward, the question is how to measure a player. A college line can be read against the player's own conference or against everyone in D1, and conferences differ a lot in strength.

Ranked against the conference or against D1

Each metric can be ranked two ways: against the player's own conference, or against all of D1. The chart compares how closely each ranking tracks where players were drafted.

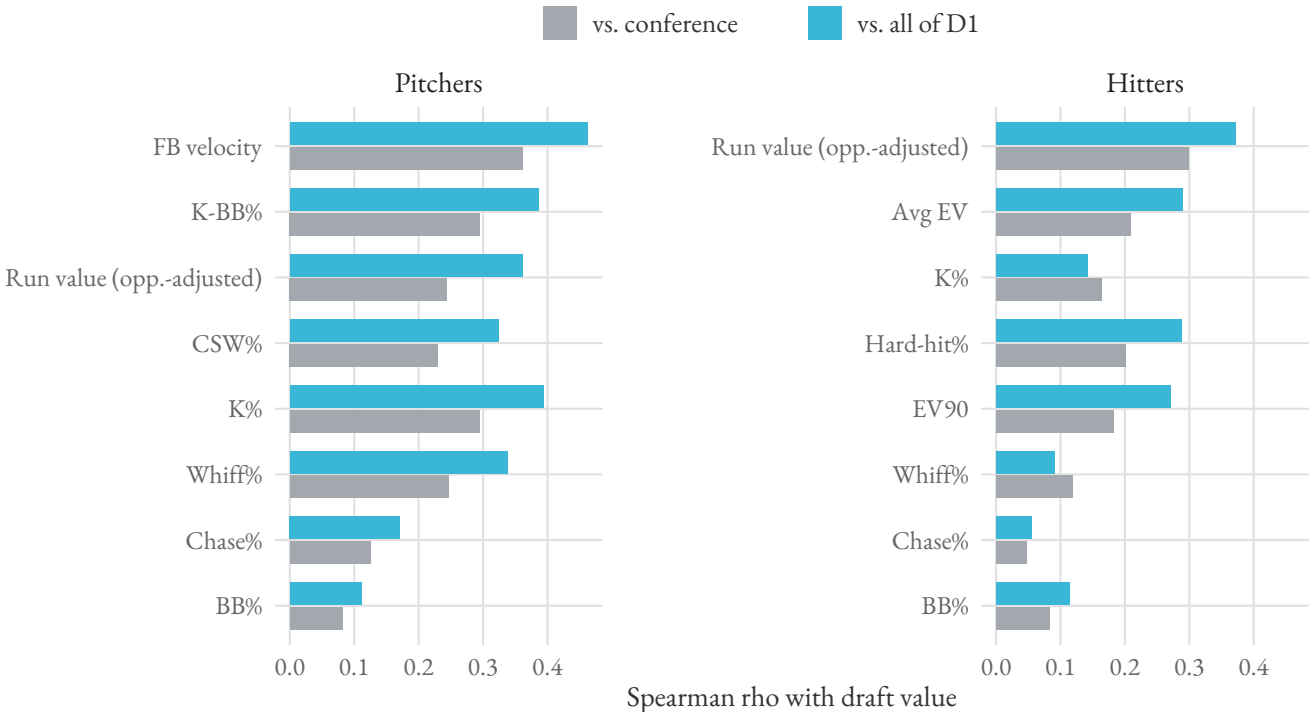


Figure 1: Spearman correlation of each metric's percentile with draft value (pick score: ln of (picks that year + 1) over overall pick, every round counts, 0 if undrafted).

The same metric, ranked against all of D1, tracks the draft better than when it is ranked only against the player's own conference. That holds for nearly every metric. For hitters, strikeout and whiff rates are the exceptions: they are slightly more informative within the conference. Opponent-adjusted run value leads for hitters. For pitchers, fastball velocity leads, followed by strikeout rate.

The same conference percentile is worth very different amounts depending on the conference. A 75th-percentile player in a strong-third conference is drafted more often than a 95th-percentile player in a weak-third one.

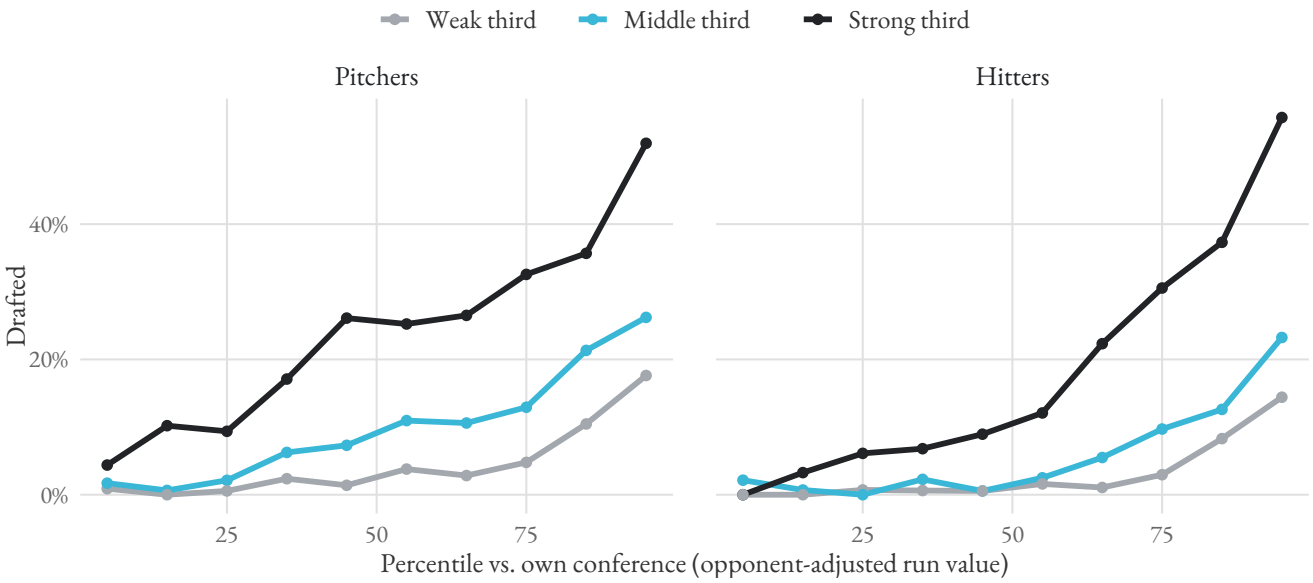


Figure 2: Draft rate by percentile against the player's own conference, split by conference strength (thirds within each season).

How strong is each conference

Team strength is a ridge fit of run value per plate appearance (offense plus run prevention) across every NCAA division, long-weighted with a three-year half-life; conference strength is the average of a conference's teams, in runs per 100 PA against an average NCAA team. Membership follows realignment season by season (see the appendix).

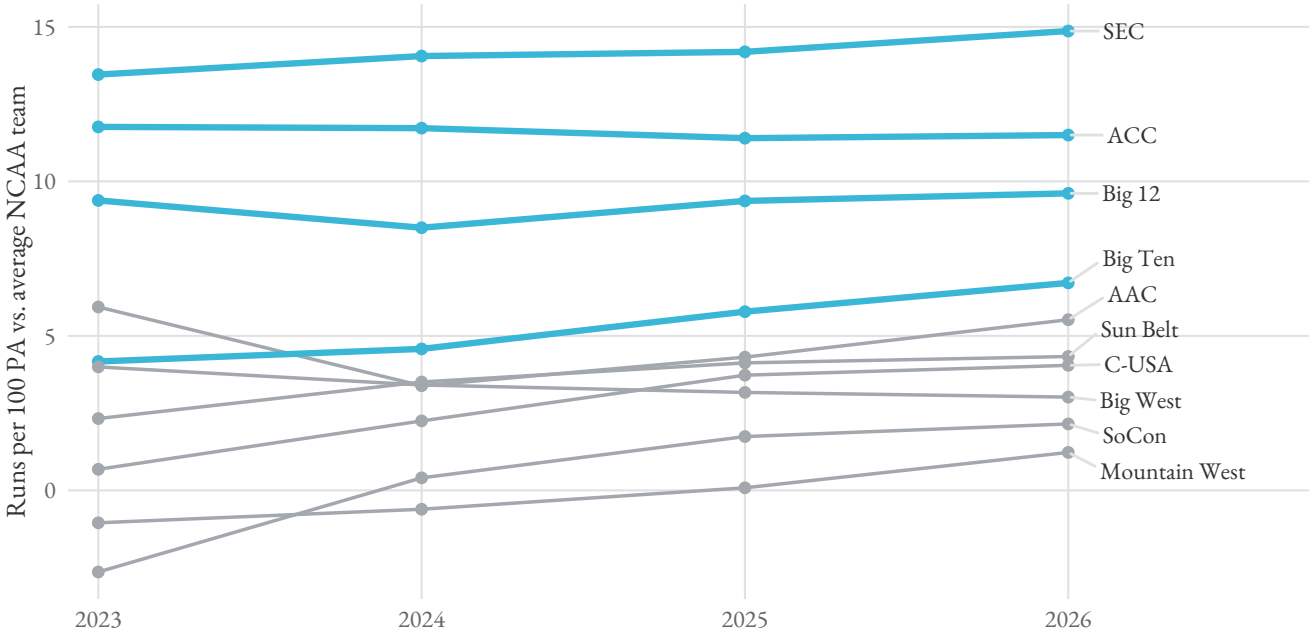


Figure 3: Long-weighted conference strength, top ten D1 conferences in 2026.

By conference

Conference by conference, the draft rate climbs with conference strength. The highest rates are the SEC (38%), Pac-12 (30%), ACC (27%), Big 12 (24%); the Pac-12 figure is mostly its 2023-24 seasons, before the breakup. The Big Ten (14%) sits with the stronger mid-majors rather than with the other power conferences.

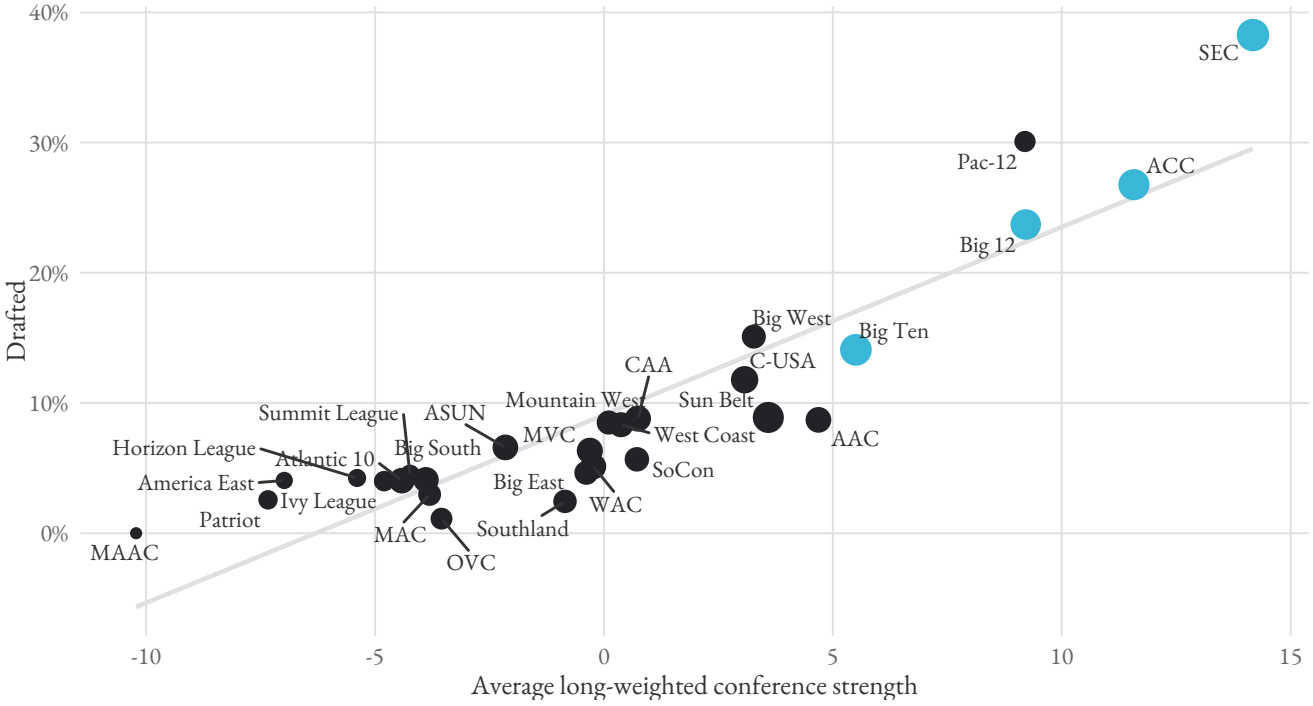


Figure 4: Draft rate of draft-eligible players by conference (season-specific membership) against average conference strength.

Which games matter

Each eligible player-season is split four ways: by the batter's or pitcher's hand, conference games vs. non-conference games, opponent tier, and month.

Run value against every kind of opponent tracks the draft, and conference games are not the most telling: for hitters, conference-game run value correlates 0.22 with draft value against 0.29 for non-conference games and 0.32 against power-conference opponents; for pitchers 0.22, 0.28 and 0.28. Part of that gap is mechanical: conference-game run value is measured against the conference itself, and the power-opponent split covers fewer players. Drafted players don't stand out by doing better in conference play than outside it (Figure 6).

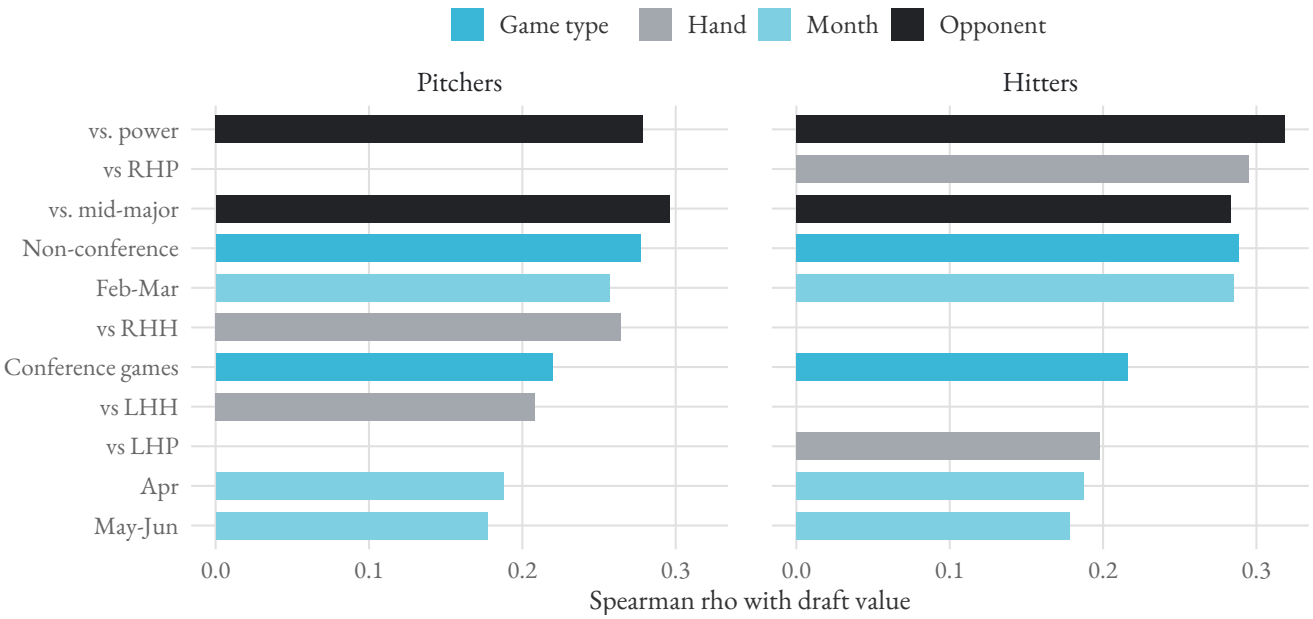


Figure 5: Spearman correlation of split run value per 100 pitches with draft value (min. 25 PA in the split).

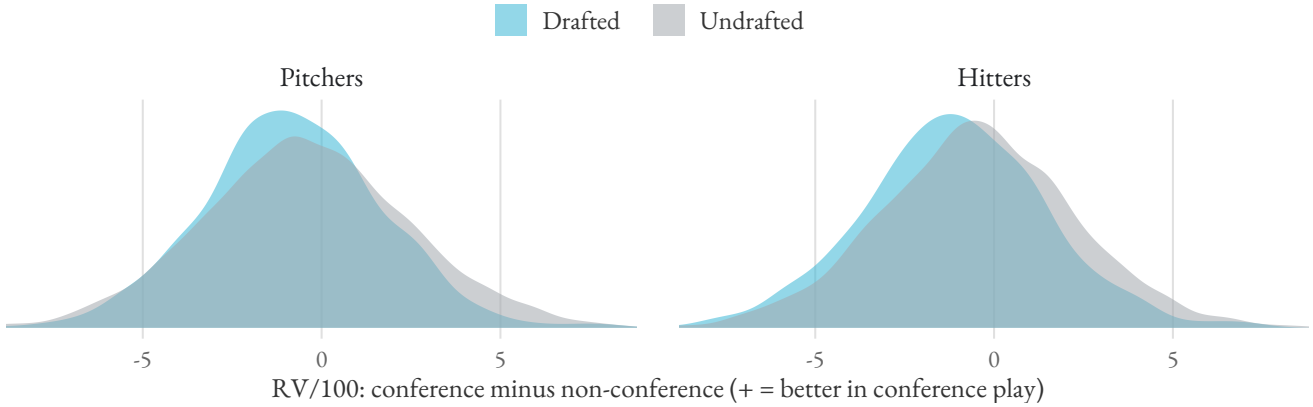


Figure 6: Conference-game run value minus non-conference run value, drafted vs. undrafted.

> **Takeaway.** Rank players against all of D1, and read any conference-relative number together with how strong the conference is. Conference games themselves are not special: the draft follows the whole line.

PART 2

What the draft pays for: tools

Production and tools both separate picks from everyone else. This part looks at the tools: the raw tools first, then at the approach and contact stats that sit around them, and ends with the profile of a typical pick by round.

Velocity and exit velocity

Raw tools carry much of the signal on their own. For pitchers it's fastball velocity, and for hitters it's the top of the exit-velocity range (EV90).

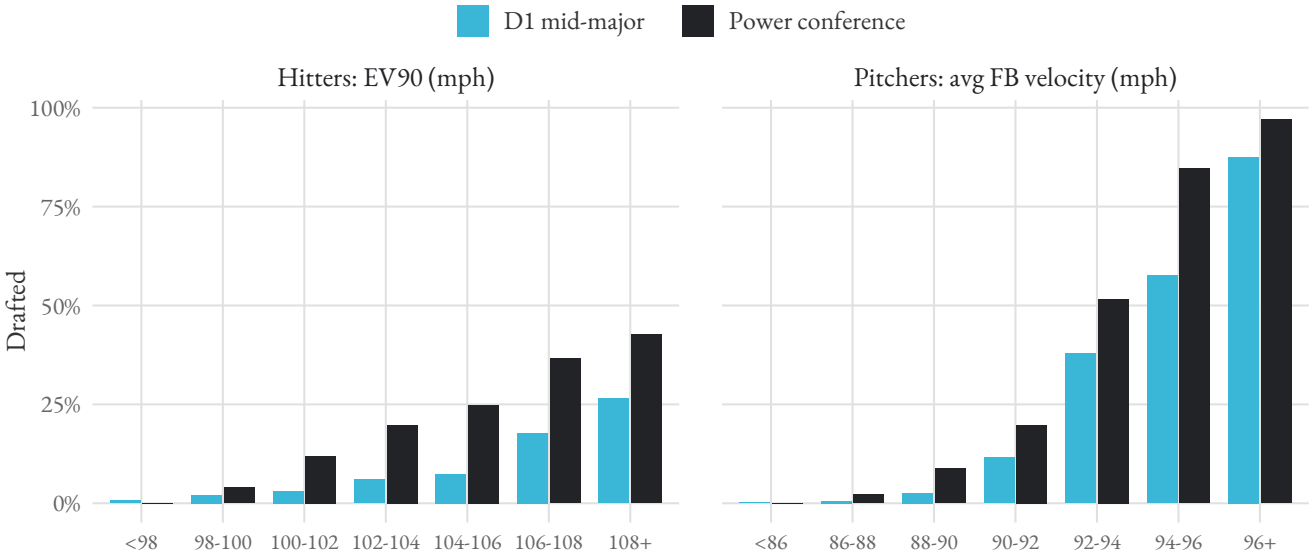


Figure 7: Draft rate by average fastball velocity (pitchers) and EV90 (hitters).

Beyond the headline tool: approach and contact

Four skill stats per role: the tool already in the models plus three more. For hitters that's EV90, in-zone whiff rate, chase rate, and pull-air rate (pulled balls hit at 10 degrees or higher, as a share of batted balls). For pitchers it's fastball velocity, zone rate, in-zone whiff rate, and soft-contact rate (batted balls under 80 mph). Each is ranked as a percentile against D1 and against the conference, oriented so that higher is better (low in-zone whiff and low chase rank high for hitters).

Of the three new tools, the strongest single signal is Zone whiff% for pitchers (rho 0.31) and Zone whiff% for hitters (0.08). Average EV and hard-hit% track the draft about as well as EV90 (0.29 and 0.29); EV90 stays as the hitter tool to match the models. Neither new tool comes close to fastball velocity (0.46) or EV90 (0.27). Ranking against all of D1 beats ranking against the conference for 6 of the 8 tools; the exceptions are pitchers' Soft contact% (0.02 vs. −0.02) and hitters' Zone whiff% (0.10 vs. 0.08), both weak signals either way, much like hitter K% and whiff% earlier.

The four tools overlap only partly. Among hitters the strongest link is Zone whiff% with EV90 (-0.41), a trade-off: the hardest hitters tend to miss more in the zone. Among pitchers it's Zone whiff% with FB velocity (0.34): velocity and in-zone bat-missing go together. Everything else is weak, so each tool carries information the others don't.

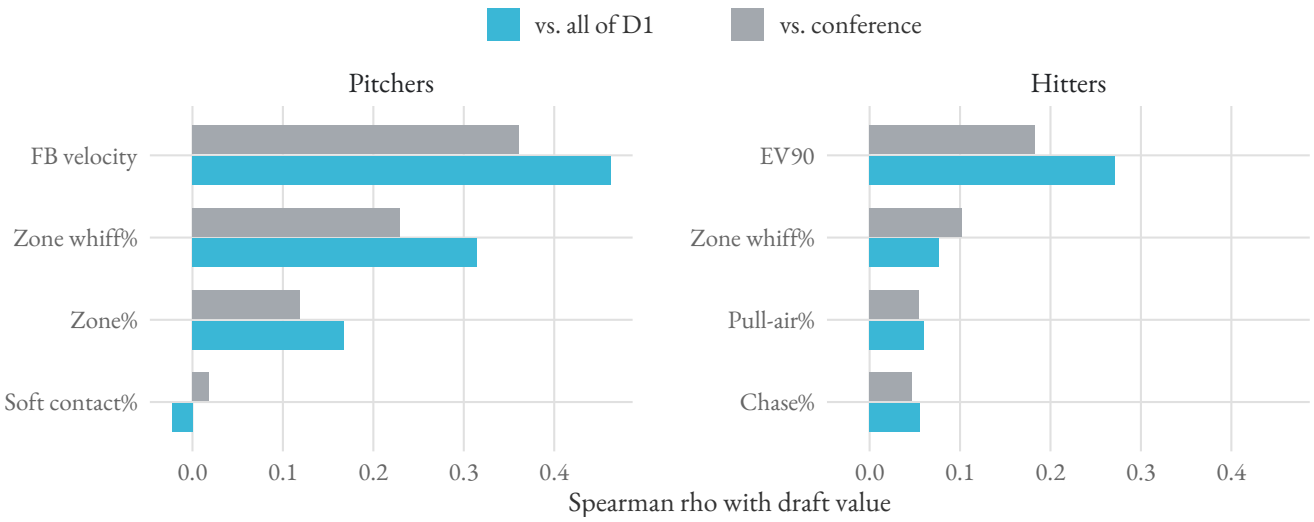


Figure 8: Spearman correlation of each tool's percentile with draft value.

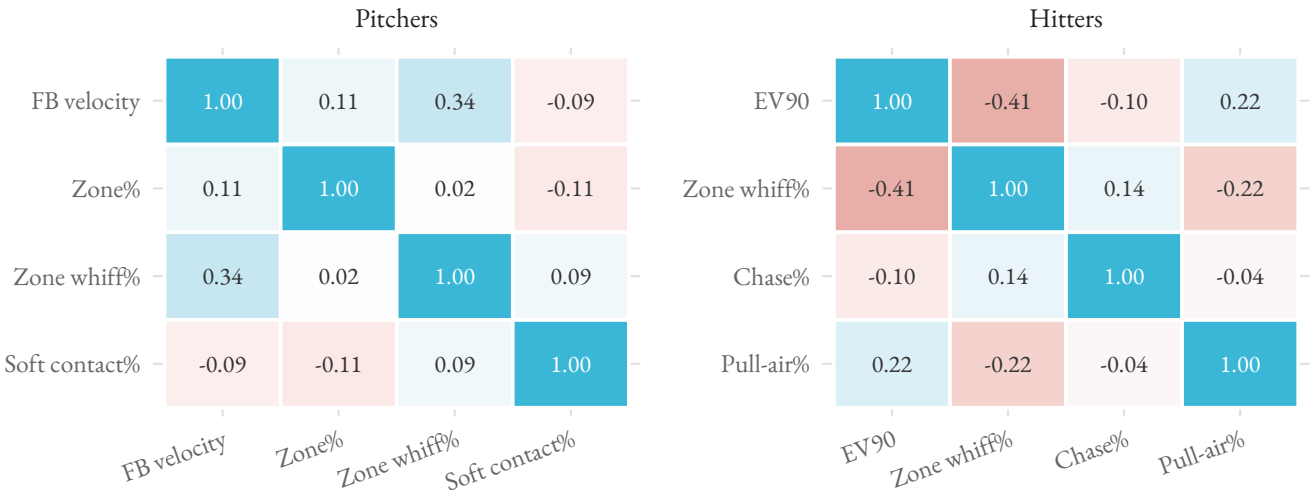


Figure 9: How the four tools relate (Spearman correlation of D1 percentiles, higher = better on every tool; cyan = strengths that go together, red = trade-offs).

Table 1: Each tool's odds ratio per 10 percentile points (95% CI), the other three tools and conference strength held equal; right column also holds the player-finder composite, which already contains some of these stats

Role	Tool	Tools + strength	Also holding the finder score
Pitchers	FB velocity	1.97 (1.85-2.10)	2.02 (1.90-2.16)
Pitchers	Soft contact%	1.06 (1.02-1.10)	0.99 (0.95-1.03)
Pitchers	Zone whiff%	1.29 (1.24-1.35)	1.16 (1.11-1.22)
Pitchers	Zone%	1.20 (1.16-1.25)	1.08 (1.04-1.12)
Hitters	Chase%	1.08 (1.04-1.11)	0.90 (0.86-0.94)
Hitters	EV90	1.64 (1.55-1.73)	1.24 (1.16-1.32)
Hitters	Pull-air%	1.07 (1.03-1.11)	1.01 (0.97-1.06)
Hitters	Zone whiff%	1.41 (1.35-1.48)	1.18 (1.12-1.25)

Adding the three new tools to the finder, conference strength and the main tool takes the cross-validated AUC from 0.920 to 0.923 for pitchers (gain 0.003, 95% interval 0.001 to 0.005) and from 0.877 to 0.886 for hitters (0.008, 0.004 to 0.014). The gains are real but small: the new tools refine the picture rather than change it (each tool's own AUC is in the appendix).

The odds ratios need care, because the player-finder composite is built partly from these same stats (chase, in-zone whiff and EV90 for hitters; zone% for pitchers). The left column holds only the other tools and conference strength equal; that is the plain answer to "does this tool matter?". With the tools alone, in-zone whiff matters for both roles (1.29× per 10 percentile points for pitchers, 1.41× for hitters), and chase discipline counts in the expected direction for hitters (1.08×). Pull-air (1.07×) and soft contact (1.06×) add a little. Holding the finder score equal as well (right column) asks what a tool adds beyond its share of the composite. There chase turns below one (0.90×), which is an artifact of conditioning on a score that already rewards chase discipline, not evidence that scouts penalize patience. Soft contact is also the noisiest of the tools: a pitcher's soft-contact rate barely carries over from one season to the next (the median pitcher has under 80 balls in play), so its weak result says as much about the measurement as about scouts.

What a pick looks like, by round

Table 2: Pitchers: draft-year averages by where they went

Round	N	FB velo	K%	BB%	Whiff%	Pctl vs. conf	Pctl vs. D1	Finder comp.	Conf. strength
Rd 1 + comp	25	95.6	34.8	8.6	35.6	84.0	93.5	0.71	11.7
Rd 2	34	93.8	31.1	8.7	31.5	82.1	91.5	0.64	9.6
Rd 3-5	120	93.3	28.3	9.2	30.0	72.6	82.5	0.52	9.0
Rd 6-10	251	92.5	26.6	9.4	28.5	72.1	78.4	0.49	6.6
Rd 11-20	387	92.1	25.6	10.1	28.1	67.9	74.9	0.39	6.0
Undrafted	5,147	88.9	19.1	11.1	22.9	52.0	50.6	0.09	1.4

Table 3: Hitters: draft-year averages by where they went

Round	N	K%	BB%	EV90	Hard-hit%	xSLG	Pctl vs. conf	Pctl vs. D1	Finder comp.	Conf. strength
Rd 1 + comp	49	14.8	14.5	107.2	53.5	0.63	92.9	95.8	0.85	10.8
Rd 2	38	14.8	13.0	106.7	49.5	0.57	84.2	89.7	0.59	8.9
Rd 3-5	102	16.4	12.8	105.6	48.5	0.55	81.7	88.4	0.53	9.2
Rd 6-10	168	16.4	12.9	104.9	46.3	0.54	80.0	84.8	0.56	6.9
Rd 11-20	211	16.9	11.8	104.3	43.8	0.50	71.8	76.7	0.37	6.0
Undrafted	4,849	19.2	11.2	102.0	35.8	0.42	52.8	51.9	0.09	1.9

Takeaway. Fastball velocity carries most of the pitcher signal; for hitters EV90 adds to production rather than leading it. In-zone whiff is the approach stat that adds most once the tools are combined; the others refine the picture.

PART 3

Putting it together

Combining performance, conference strength and a tool gives a simple draft model, and a fair benchmark for the player finder.

Model comparison

Logistic models of drafted (yes/no), fit separately for pitchers and hitters. Every model in a role uses the same players. AUC is the chance a model ranks a random drafted player above a random undrafted one (0.5 is a coin flip). The values shown are cross-validated: 10 folds, with each player's seasons held out together. In-sample values are within 0.01 of these, so the models are not overfit.

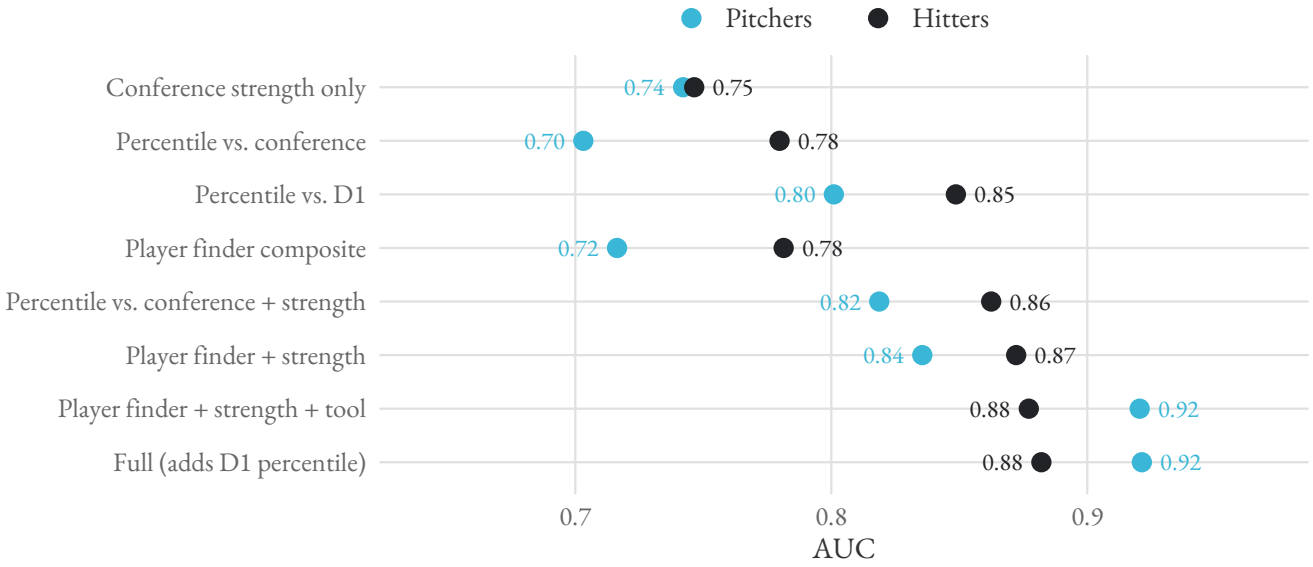


Figure 10: Cross-validated AUC by model (player-grouped 10-fold).

The real use is forward in time: fit on past drafts, then rank next year's players. Fit only on 2023-2025 and scored on the 2026 draft, the performance + strength + tool model reaches an AUC of 0.93 for pitchers and 0.90 for hitters; fit on 2023-2024 and scored on 2025, 0.91 and 0.88. Those match what the same model gets on each draft when it has seen it (0.93 and 0.90 on 2026), so nothing is lost by not seeing the year being scored. The differences between years (2026 is easier to sort than the pooled cross-validated 0.92 and 0.88) are about the draft class, not the model.

Table 4: AUC on a later draft, fit only on earlier drafts (2025: fit on 2023-2024; 2026: fit on 2023-2025)

Role	Model	Scored on 2025	Scored on 2026
Pitchers	Percentile vs. D1	0.833	0.814
Pitchers	Player finder + strength	0.853	0.854
Pitchers	Player finder + strength + tool	0.912	0.929
Pitchers	Full (adds D1 percentile)	0.914	0.930
Hitters	Percentile vs. D1	0.820	0.894
Hitters	Player finder + strength	0.871	0.903
Hitters	Player finder + strength + tool	0.879	0.902
Hitters	Full (adds D1 percentile)	0.871	0.908

Table 5: Full model, odds ratios

Term	Pitchers OR	Pitchers 95% CI	Pitchers p	Hitters OR	Hitters 95% CI	Hitters p
Player finder composite	5.67	3.93-8.24	<0.0001	7.05	4.64-10.79	<0.0001
Conference strength (per run/100 PA)	1.09	1.07-1.11	<0.0001	1.15	1.13-1.18	<0.0001
Tool percentile vs. D1 (velo / EV90), per 10	2.09	1.96-2.24	<0.0001	1.13	1.07-1.18	<0.0001
Percentile vs. D1, per 10	1.14	1.06-1.23	0.00041	1.33	1.23-1.45	<0.0001

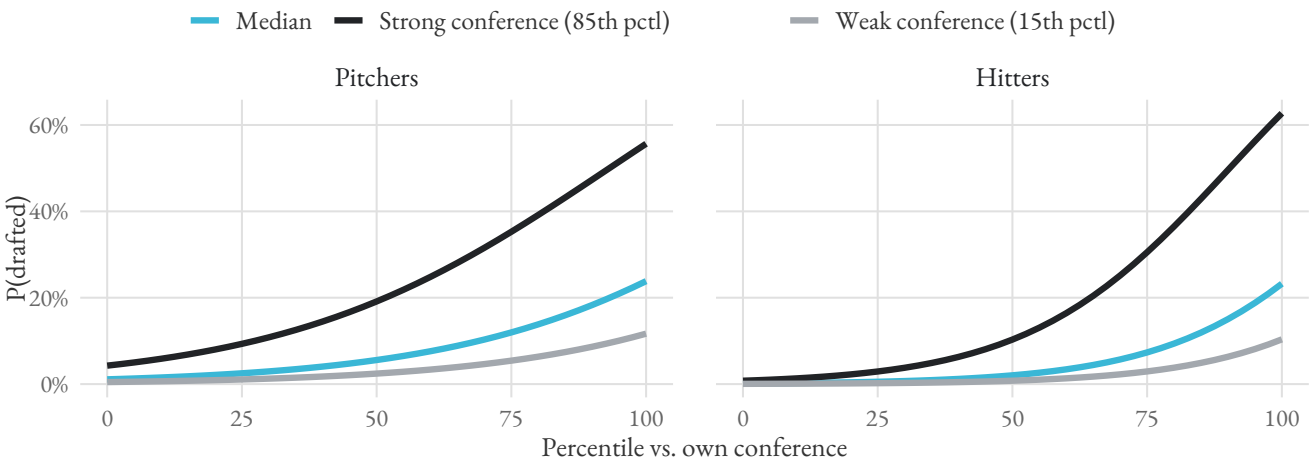


Figure 11: Model draft probability by percentile against the player's own conference, 2026 draft.

The player finder as a draft screen

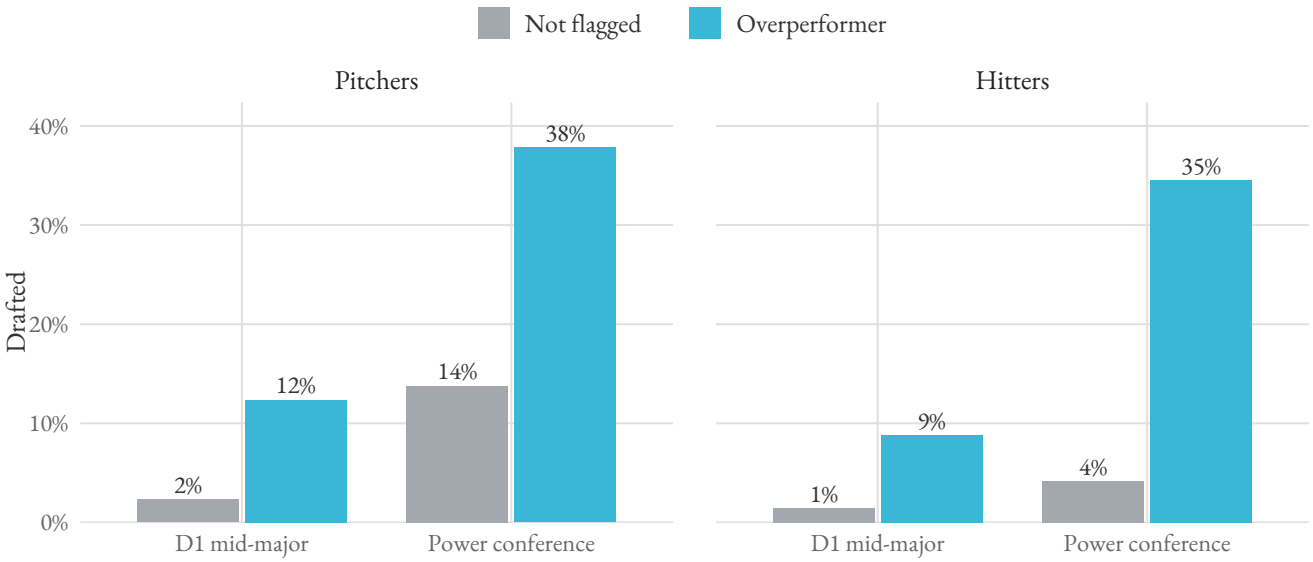


Figure 12: Draft rate of draft-eligible players: player finder overperformers vs. everyone else.

The player finder flags a player who clears his tier's bar against his conference and handedness group on at least 70% of tracked stats, with a composite z-score of zero or better. It knows nothing about the draft, but it is a broad flag: about 62% of eligible players get it, so the big ratio between flagged and unflagged players mostly reflects how rarely the bottom 40% get drafted. The fair test is against a plain cut that flags the same share of players, using opponent-adjusted run value against D1:

Table 6: Power-conference draft-eligible players: finder flag vs. a same-size cut on run value (player-clustered 95% intervals)

Role	Rule	Share flagged	Drafted if flagged	Drafted if not
Pitchers	Player finder flag	61%	37.8% (35%-41%)	13.8% (11%-16%)
Pitchers	Top cut on run value vs. D1	61%	39.7% (37%-43%)	10.8% (8%-13%)
Hitters	Player finder flag	59%	34.5% (31%-38%)	4.2% (3%-6%)
Hitters	Top cut on run value vs. D1	59%	34.4% (32%-37%)	4.3% (3%-6%)

The two rules perform about the same. As a single score, the finder composite (cross-validated AUC 0.72 for pitchers, 0.78 for hitters) trails the plain percentile against D1 (0.80 and 0.85). Its value is as a quick, conference-aware scouting screen, not as a better draft predictor.

> **Takeaway.** Performance, conference strength and one tool sort drafted from undrafted players well, and keep doing so on a later draft. As a yes/no flag the player finder does about as well as a plain run-value cut; as a score it trails the D1 percentile.

PART 4

Shortcuts? Transfers and high-school pedigree

Two paths look like they should change a player's draft odds: moving up to a stronger conference before the draft, and having been drafted out of high school. Both groups are drafted more often. The question is whether the path adds anything once the player's own performance is known.

The draft year counts most

The draft year tracks the draft better than the season before it (Spearman 0.36 vs. 0.27 for pitchers, 0.37 vs. 0.28 for hitters), and most drafted players with an earlier D1 season had their best season in the draft year. That is what makes a move for the draft year tempting.

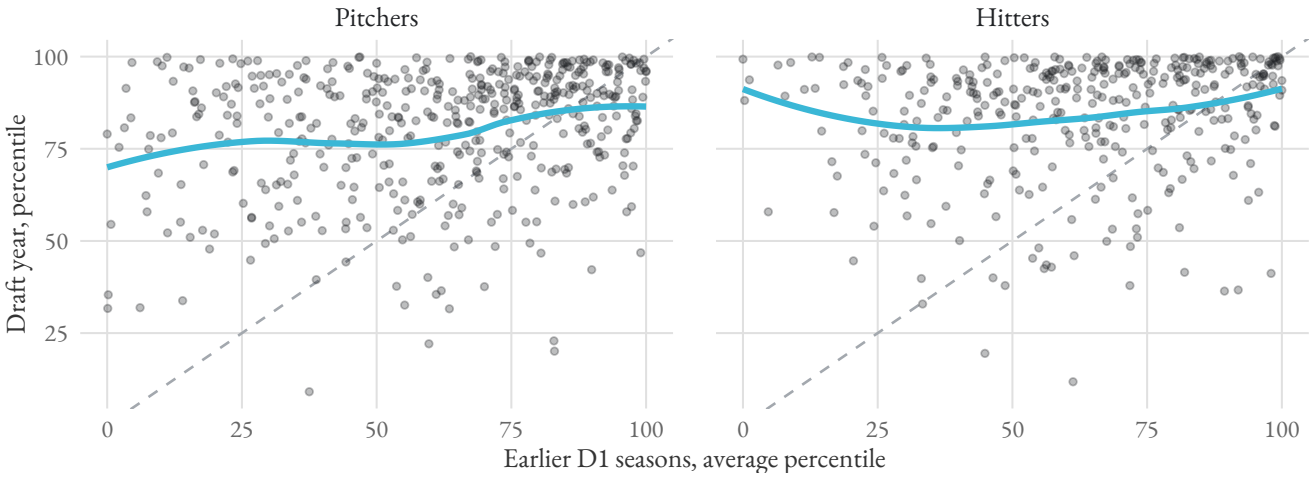


Figure 13: Drafted players: draft-year percentile vs. D1 against their earlier D1 seasons.

Of drafted players, 76% sit above the dashed line: their draft-year percentile beat the average of their earlier D1 seasons, and 67% beat their best earlier season (836 drafted players with an earlier D1 season on record). Most of them were already above the 50th percentile before it.

Moving up a conference

Who moved

Transfer status compares the draft season with the season right before it. That prior season comes from TrackMan in any division, or from last year's D1 roster when TrackMan doesn't have it. **Stayed** means the same team both years. **Up** and **down** are moves to another D1 team whose conference is more than 2 runs per 100 PA stronger or weaker, both measured in the same season with real membership. Moves from JUCO, D2, D3 or NAIA form their own group, because strength across divisions can't be measured reliably here. Players with no prior season on record are also their own group, not lumped in with stayers.

Class matters as much as the move. Players who move up are older on average, and juniors are drafted far more often than seniors or graduate students. So the raw comparison has to be made within class:

In 5 of the 6 role-and-class groups, players who moved up were drafted more often than players who stayed. The gap is largest for juniors; among graduate students the rates are about the same. That is the raw picture. The next question is whether it survives holding the players' numbers equal.

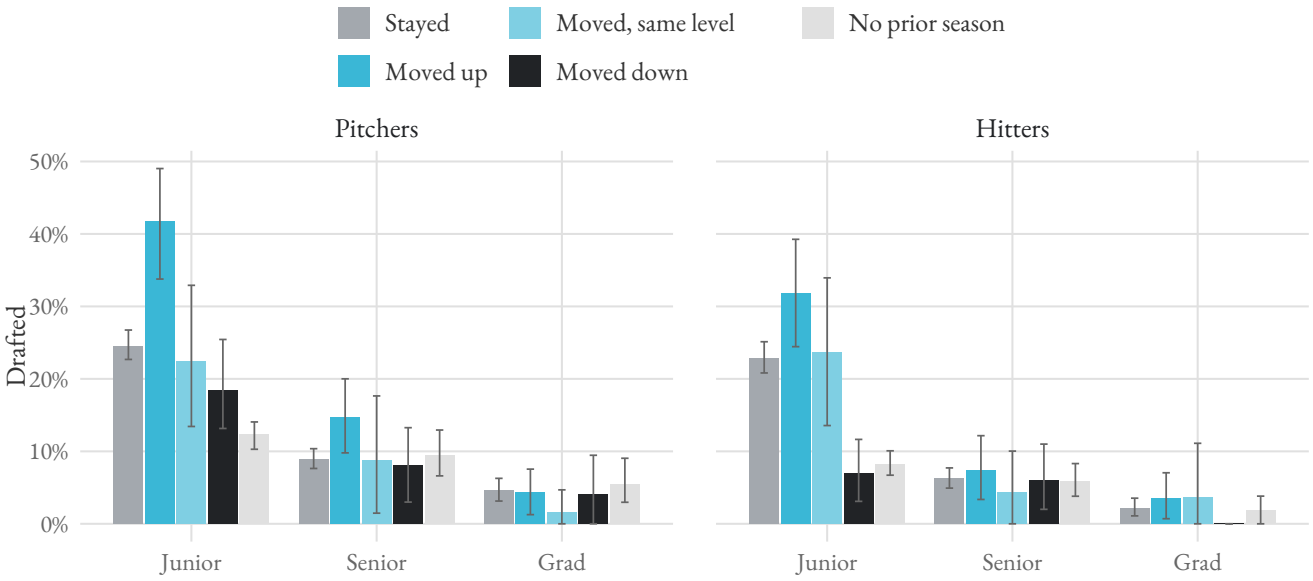


Figure 14: Draft rate by class and transfer status (95% bootstrap intervals; groups of 10+ players).

Three ways to compare

The same mover-vs.-stayer question gives different answers depending on what is held equal:

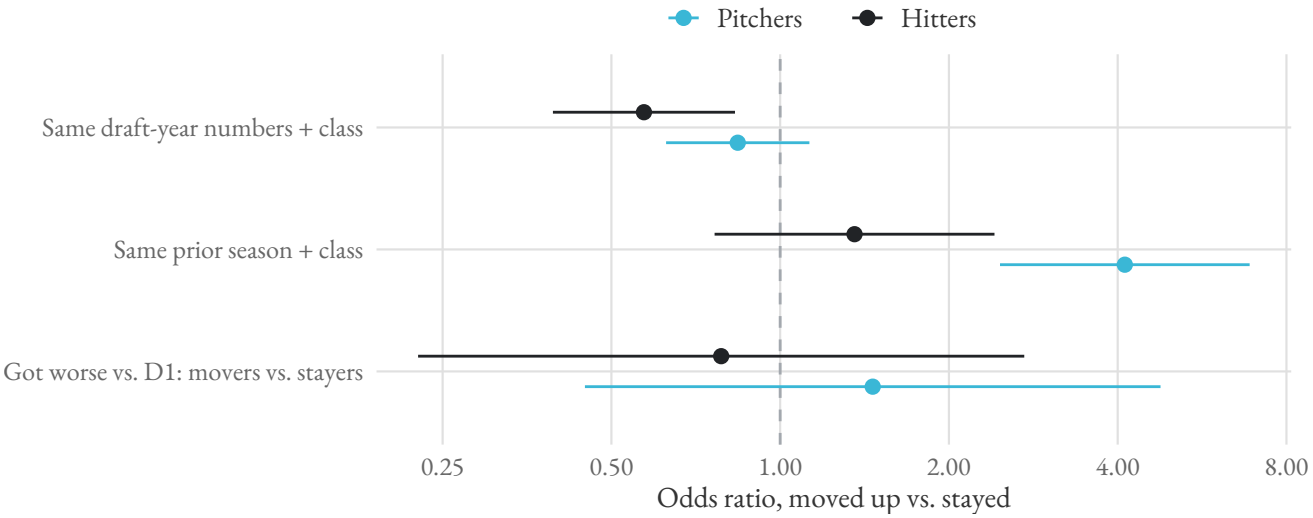


Figure 15: Odds ratio for moving up vs. staying, by design (player-clustered 95% intervals, log scale).

- **Same draft-year numbers + class.** This holds fixed the player's percentile against his new conference, the conference's strength and his class. It asks: among players who put up the same draft-year line in the same kind of conference, are the movers drafted differently? Hitters who moved up were drafted less often (0.57× the odds). For pitchers there is no clear difference (0.84×). The draft-year line is partly a result of the move, so this comparison understates whatever the move does.
- **Same prior season + class.** This uses only what was known before the move: last season's percentile against his conference, that conference's strength and class. Pitchers who moved up were drafted far more often than similar pitchers who stayed (4.1×, 2.5-6.9). Hitters show no clear difference (1.36×). The likeliest reading is selection: power programs recruit up the pitchers whose stuff scouts already like. This design (and the got-worse comparison below) needs the prior season in TrackMan, which covers only 26% of moves, and those pitchers are a better-drafted group: 29% of TrackMan-matched pitchers who moved up were drafted vs. 17% of those found through rosters. Read the

4.1× as describing that group, not every pitcher who moves up.

- **Got worse vs. D1: movers vs. stayers.** This is the case in question, set out below.

When the move happened

A one-season move for the draft year is not the same as moving up early and spending two or more seasons in the stronger conference. Each player's path over the four seasons before the draft comes from TrackMan, with the D1 rosters filling gaps. It gives his years at his current school and where he was before that. **Moved up, draft year** means the draft season is his first at the new school. **Moved up, 2+ seasons before** means he moved up earlier and stayed. **Stayed** means two or more seasons at the same school and no earlier school on record.

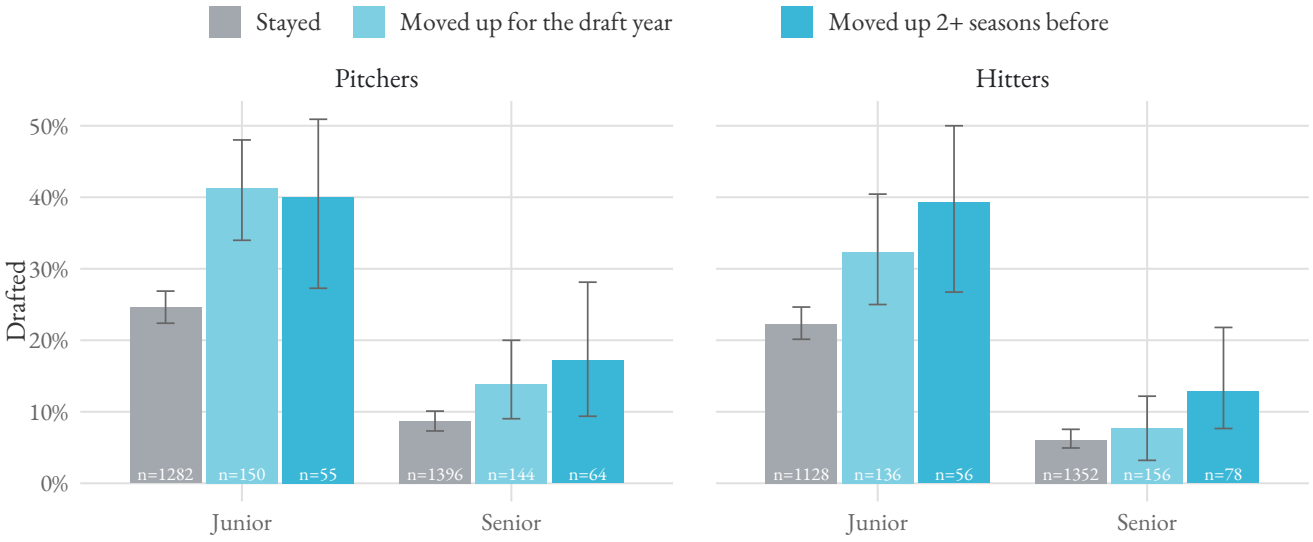


Figure 16: Draft rate by class and when the player moved up (95% player-clustered bootstrap intervals).

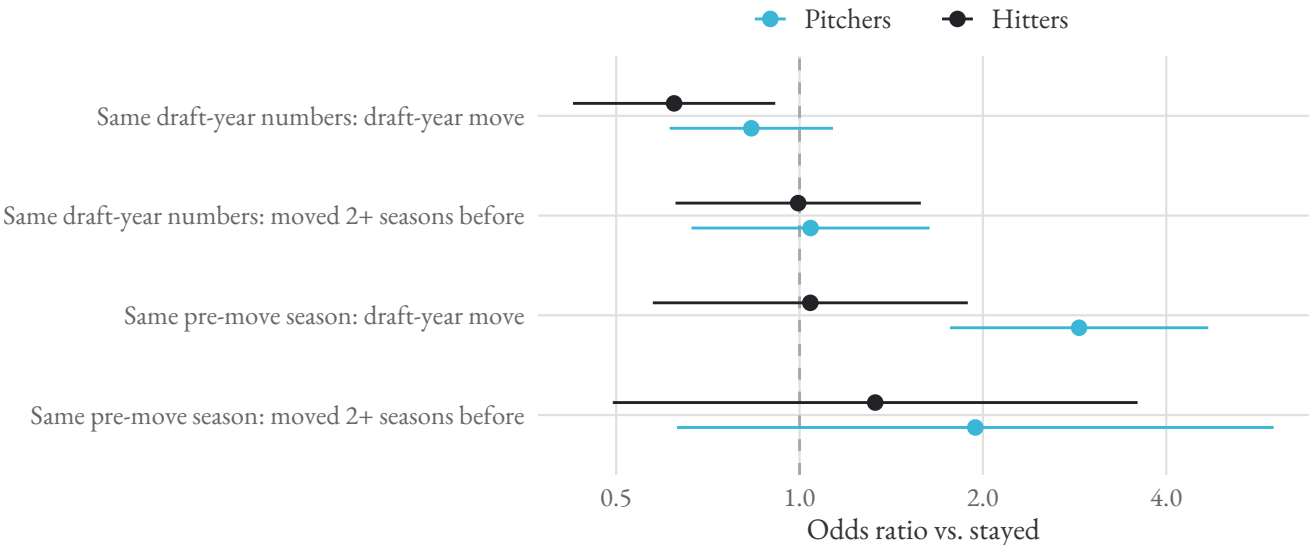


Figure 17: Odds ratio vs. players who stayed, by when they moved up (player-clustered 95% intervals, log scale).

For **hitters**, the two kinds of move differ at equal draft-year numbers. A hitter who moved up for the draft year was drafted less often than a stayer with the same draft-year line (0.62×). A hitter who moved up two or more seasons before the draft shows no such gap (0.99×). Measured from before the move, neither kind of hitter mover stands out: draft-year movers 1.04×, early movers 1.33× (0.5-3.6). The early-mover comparison measures stayers from two seasons back too. An early mover's pre-move season is older, and an older season predicts the draft less well, so comparing it with a

stayer's most recent season made early movers look far better than their numbers. For **pitchers**, neither kind of mover is penalized at equal draft-year numbers. Pitchers who moved up for the draft year (again only those TrackMan saw before the move) were drafted far more often than their pre-move season predicts (2.9×, 1.8-4.7). Early movers point the same way (1.9×), but the group is too small for the interval to exclude no difference. The early-mover groups are small (n shown in the chart). The usual caution applies: programs recruit up the players they expect to develop.

Moved up and got worse

This compares players who moved up and got worse with players who stayed and also got worse. It holds equal their prior percentile, prior conference strength, how far they fell, and class; the interval comes from a bootstrap over players. "Got worse" can be defined two ways, and the choice matters:

- **Against all of D1** (the main definition): the player's D1 percentile fell, so he really performed worse.
- **Against his own conference** (the original question): his conference percentile fell. A move up drops the conference percentile almost by itself, because the new conference is stronger. Pitchers who moved up and "got worse" this way lost only 3 D1 percentile points on average, against 21 for stayers who got worse. This version also holds the change in D1 percentile equal, but that only partly levels the groups.

Table 7: Players who got worse: moving up vs. staying, by how "worse" is defined

Role	Got worse	Movers	Stayers	D1 pctl change, movers / stayers	Movers drafted	Expected had they stayed	Difference
Pitchers	vs. D1	40	765	−18 / −22	17.5%	14.4%	+3.1 pts (−5.7 to +14.3)
Pitchers	vs. own conference	75	799	−3 / −21	22.7%	10.3%	+12.4 pts (+4.1 to +20.6)
Hitters	vs. D1	64	704	−22 / −23	7.8%	8.9%	−1.1 pts (−6.7 to +4.6)
Hitters	vs. own conference	93	738	−12 / −21	9.7%	7.5%	+2.2 pts (−2.9 to +6.8)

Measured against all of D1, pitchers who moved up and got worse were drafted about 3 points more often than comparable stayers, with an interval from −6 to 14; for hitters the difference is −1 point, also within noise. The apparent pitcher advantage under the conference definition (12 points) comes mostly from movers whose numbers held up against D1 but ranked lower in the tougher league. So a pitcher whose line held steady in a stronger conference keeps his draft stock, which is the "same production, tougher league" story. A pitcher who actually got worse after moving up shows no clear advantage over one who got worse at home, though these groups are small and the interval is wide. None of it measures what the move itself does.

Drafted out of high school

Who was drafted out of high school

A high-school pick who doesn't sign goes to college and can be drafted again. Earlier high-school picks (2015-2025) are matched to college players by name and home state; the match finds 93% of the players whose MLB id shows an earlier pick, with no false matches (details in the appendix). That leaves 118 eligible players in 2023-2026 who were high-school picks. Their picks come from 2018 (18), 2019 (44), 2021 (22), 2022 (20), 2023 (17); the 2020 draft had 5 rounds and 2021-2022 had 20, so few unsigned high-school picks exist from those years. Almost all are picks from round 11 or later who chose college; 2 went in the top 10 rounds.

As juniors, 51% of hitters and 58% of pitchers who were high-school picks were drafted, against 17% and 20% of everyone else. The gap holds in 7 of the 8 role-and-class groups; not for grad hitters (0% of 14), where the high-school picks are few.

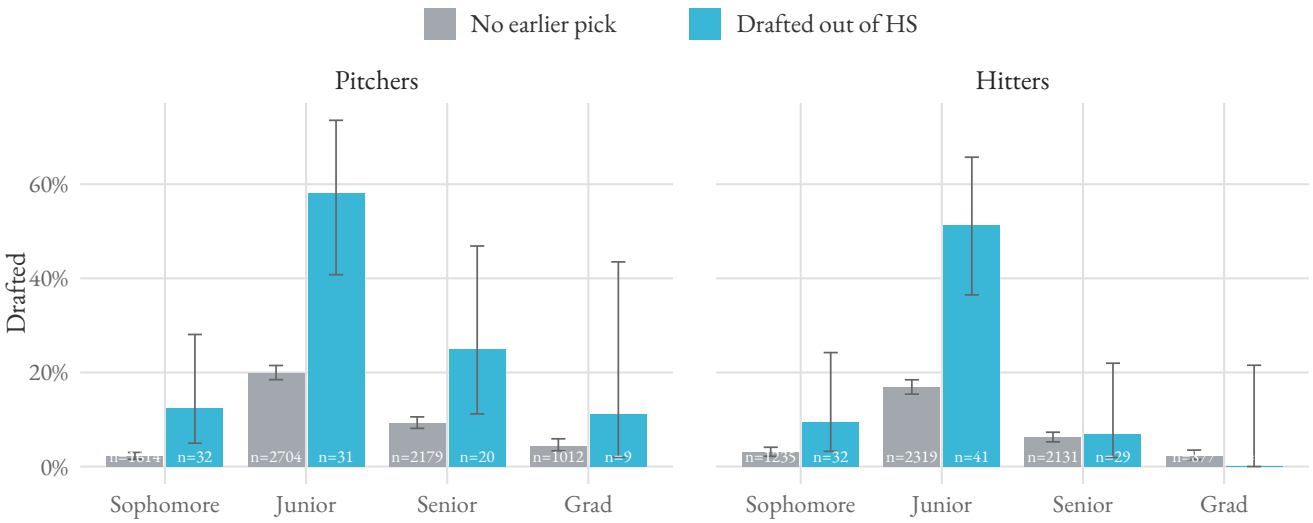


Figure 18: Draft rate by class: drafted out of high school vs. no earlier high-school or JUCO pick (95% Wilson intervals; sophomores from the all-sophomore pool).

Pedigree or performance?

Table 8: High-school draftees vs. everyone else: college profile (latest eligible season; percentiles vs. D1; tool = FB velocity or EV90; earliest = earliest observed earlier D1 season, with how many players have one)

Role	Group	Players	Earliest D1 pctl (n)	Eligible-season pctl	Tool pctl	Power conf.	Conf. strength	Drafted
Pitchers	No earlier pick	4,651	51 (1831)	55	53	26%	2.2	17%
Pitchers	Drafted out of HS	52	69 (21)	72	75	71%	8.5	46%
Hitters	No earlier pick	4,085	52 (1682)	56	54	28%	2.5	13%
Hitters	Drafted out of HS	70	65 (30)	63	73	50%	6.9	33%

High-school draftees land in stronger programs with better tools. 71% of the pitchers and 50% of the hitters play in a power conference (26% and 28% of the rest), and their fastball velocity and EV90 sit around the 75th and 73rd D1 percentiles. Their earliest observed D1 season (usually one or two seasons before, not the freshman year; TrackMan D1 coverage is thin before 2023) is already well above average: around the 69th percentile for pitchers and the 65th for hitters, against the low 50s. They also keep improving. At the same starting percentile and the same number of seasons in between, high-school pitchers gained 12 percentile points more than other pitchers (5 to 19, 21 pitchers); for hitters the difference is 4 points and within noise. A raw comparison of gains would miss this: players who start near the top have less room to climb and tend to slip back toward average.

With only class and season held equal, a high-school pick has 4.2× (2.5-7.1) the draft odds of other pitchers and 3.2× (2.0-5.3) those of other hitters. Holding conference strength equal roughly halves that, to 2.2× (1.2-3.9) and 1.9× (1.1-3.4). Once the player's D1 percentile and his tool are held equal as well, it falls to 1.2× (0.5-2.6) for pitchers and 1.4× (0.7-2.9) for hitters, neither distinguishable from no effect; the finder-score version and the all-sophomore pool say the same. The high-school edge is the college performance and the programs these players reach, not a pedigree bonus on top.

Where the pick lands tells the same story. Among drafted players with the same performance, high-school picks went slightly earlier for pitchers (pick score +0.30, $p = 0.15$) and slightly later for hitters (−0.12, $p = 0.60$): no clear difference either way.

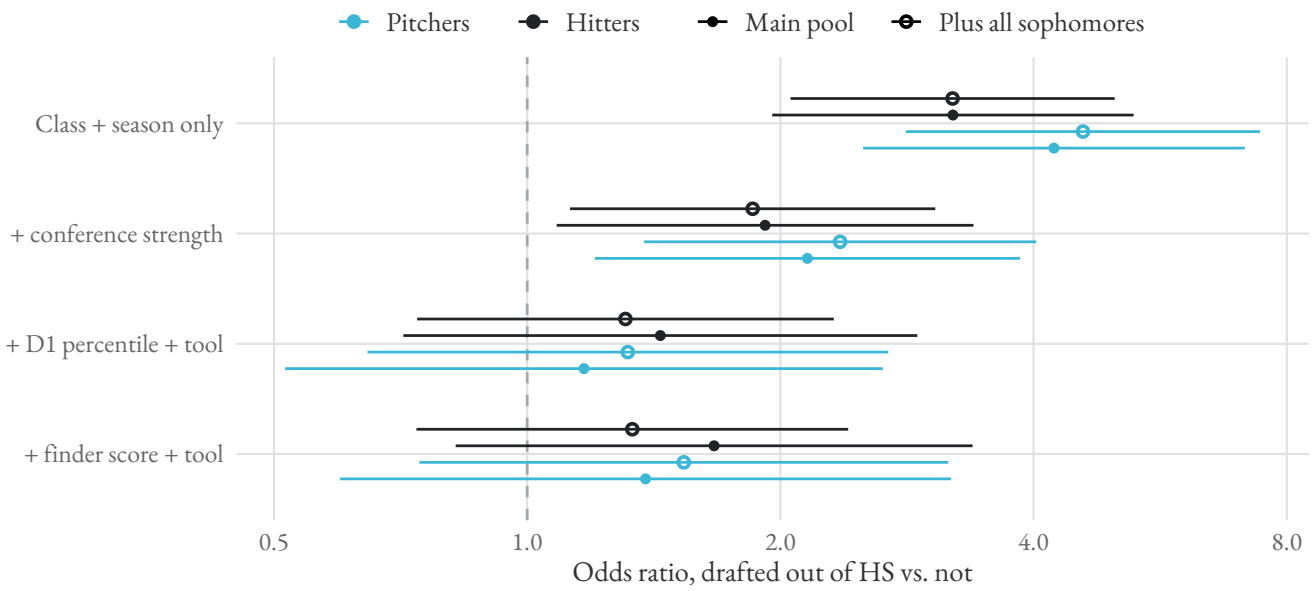


Figure 19: Odds ratio for having been drafted out of high school, by what is held equal (player-clustered 95% intervals, log scale).

What these comparisons can and can't say.

Moving up. Movers differ from stayers before they move. They are older, and good pitchers are recruited up. With performance held equal at the draft year, hitters who moved up were drafted less often. With performance held equal before the move, pitchers who moved up were drafted more often, but once they genuinely got worse against D1 the advantage is no longer clear. Neither comparison measures the effect of the move itself. About 74% of moves are identified from rosters rather than TrackMan. Dropping those leaves the draft-year comparison about the same, but the prior-season and got-worse comparisons can only use the TrackMan-matched movers, and among pitchers those are a better-drafted group.

High-school picks. A high-school pick is a scouting verdict made before college, so it measures talent, not a label scouts reward for its own sake. The matching misses about 7% of earlier picks and probably includes a few namesakes among the undrafted. Both errors put the wrong players in the wrong group and pull the gap toward zero. Drafted players list a hometown slightly more often than undrafted ones (99% vs. 96%), which nudges the high-school draft rate up a little. "No earlier pick" means no earlier high-school or JUCO pick; a few of these players were drafted in an earlier college season.

Takeaway. Movers and high-school picks are drafted more often mostly because they are better players in stronger programs. At equal draft-year performance neither path adds a clear boost; pitchers who moved up do beat their prior season, most likely because programs recruit the pitchers scouts already like.

APPENDIX

Data and methods

Data

Every MLB draft pick from 2021 to 2026, all rounds, comes from the MLB StatsAPI with the school, class and slot value. College picks are linked to TrackMan by name and school: 94% of 4-year picks from 2023 on link, including all 176 first-to-third-round 4-year picks from 2024 on. TrackMan coverage before 2023 is too thin, so the analysis covers the 2023-2026 drafts. Class years come from every D1 roster from 2021 to 2026, scraped from each school's season archive pages, with Internet Archive copies where a school keeps none. Each roster is checked against that season's TrackMan players.

Table 9: Draft-eligible D1 player-seasons (min. 60 PA faced for pitchers, 80 PA for hitters)

Season	Eligible	Drafted	Draft rate	Pitchers	Hitters	Transfers
2023	1,902	300	15.8%	1,037	865	250
2024	2,621	338	12.9%	1,365	1,256	406
2025	3,149	355	11.3%	1,625	1,524	541
2026	3,709	392	10.6%	1,937	1,772	748

Who counts as draft-eligible

A 4-year player is eligible after his junior year, or if he is 21 within 45 days after the draft. Every sophomore drafted from 2021 to 2026 met the age test in that 45-day form. Birth dates exist only for players who were drafted, so the age route can't be applied to undrafted sophomores. The main pool is therefore class-based for everyone: juniors, seniors, graduate students and redshirt sophomores and up, drafted or not. Adding every sophomore as an upper bound moves the headline model modestly (AUCs here are in-sample):

Table 10: Main pool vs. adding every sophomore (finder + strength + tool model)

Pool	Role	Eligible	Draft rate	AUC	Finder composite OR	Conf. strength OR
Main pool	Pitchers	5,851	13.7%	0.922	9.4	1.115
Main pool	Hitters	5,355	10.6%	0.879	20.2	1.198
Plus all sophomores	Pitchers	7,483	11.2%	0.904	7.0	1.087
Plus all sophomores	Hitters	6,614	9.1%	0.871	16.0	1.178

Table 11: Draft rate by class

Role	Class	Players	Draft rate	Picks in Rd 1-5
Pitchers	Grad / R-Sr	1,021	4.5%	7%
Pitchers	Junior (1st eligible year)	2,744	20.6%	29%
Pitchers	Senior / R-Jr	2,199	9.4%	7%
Hitters	Grad / R-Sr	891	2.2%	5%
Hitters	Junior (1st eligible year)	2,364	17.5%	44%
Hitters	Senior / R-Jr	2,162	6.2%	5%

Conference realignment

From 2024 on, each team sits in the conference it actually played in that season, read from TrackMan's game-level league labels (the most common label across the team's games, where it covers at least 60% of 20+ tracked games). Earlier seasons, or teams with unclear labels, use the fixed team reference.

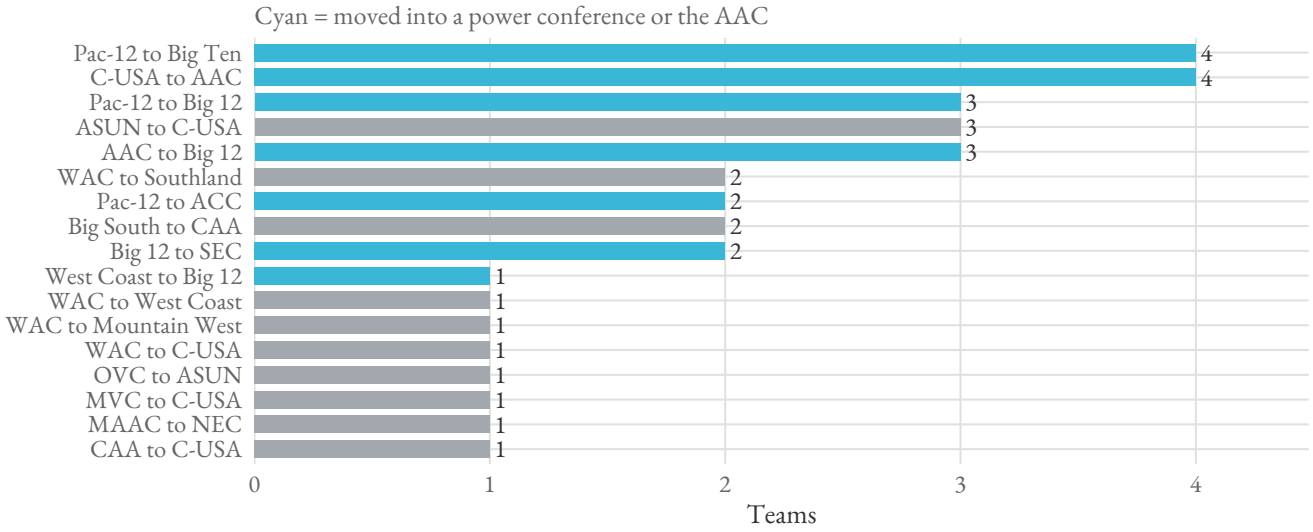


Figure 20: Teams whose conference changed from the fixed reference, 2024-2026.

Transfer sensitivity

Table 12: Moved up vs. stayed under alternative choices (player-clustered intervals)

Role	Check	Odds ratio	95% CI	N
Pitchers	Draft-year design (main)	0.84	0.63-1.13	5,913
Pitchers	Drop roster-inferred transfers	1.23	0.78-1.96	3,489
Pitchers	Exclude 2026	0.86	0.61-1.23	3,992
Pitchers	Juniors only	1.02	0.68-1.54	2,729
Pitchers	Up threshold 0 runs/100 PA	0.85	0.64-1.13	5,913
Pitchers	Up threshold 5 runs/100 PA	0.85	0.62-1.16	5,913
Pitchers	Pre-transfer design	4.12	2.47-6.88	1,950
Hitters	Draft-year design (main)	0.57	0.39-0.83	5,382
Hitters	Drop roster-inferred transfers	0.47	0.25-0.88	3,173
Hitters	Exclude 2026	0.53	0.34-0.82	3,619
Hitters	Juniors only	0.70	0.43-1.14	2,354
Hitters	Up threshold 0 runs/100 PA	0.59	0.41-0.85	5,382
Hitters	Up threshold 5 runs/100 PA	0.54	0.36-0.81	5,382
Hitters	Pre-transfer design	1.36	0.76-2.41	1,912

High-school matching

A high-school pick who doesn't sign goes to college and can be drafted again. Every pick from 2015 to 2025 comes from the MLB StatsAPI. The feed leaves the school level blank for 2015-2017 and 2019, so for 5,683 picks it is inferred from the school name (the same school labelled in another year, else words like "HS", "Academy", "JC" or "University"); 676 stay unknown and are left out. A high-school (or JUCO) pick is matched to a draft-eligible college player one to seven years later by name and home state: the state on his roster hometown must equal the pick's school, home or birth state. The same rule is applied to every player, drafted or not.

Two checks. Players drafted again from college carry the same MLB id in both drafts: of the 59 college draftees whose id shows an earlier high-school or JUCO pick, the rule found 55 (93%), with no false matches; 2 of the misses have no hometown on their roster. Undrafted players can't be checked that way, so the matching was rerun with home states shuffled across players: chance agreement alone produces about 10 matches, against 134 real ones. A handful of the undrafted "high-school picks" are probably namesakes.

Approach and contact tools: model fit

Table 13: Cross-validated AUC: each tool alone, all four, and all four added to finder + conference strength

Role	Model	AUC
Pitchers	FB velocity alone	0.884
Pitchers	Zone% alone	0.642
Pitchers	Zone whiff% alone	0.764
Pitchers	Soft contact% alone	0.533
Pitchers	All four tools	0.905
Pitchers	Finder + strength + FB velocity	0.920
Pitchers	Finder + strength + all four tools	0.923
Hitters	EV90 alone	0.754
Hitters	Zone whiff% alone	0.581
Hitters	Chase% alone	0.566
Hitters	Pull-air% alone	0.574
Hitters	All four tools	0.817
Hitters	Finder + strength + EV90	0.877
Hitters	Finder + strength + all four tools	0.886

Methods

- **Population.** D1 player-seasons 2023-2026 with at least 60 PA faced (pitchers) or 80 PA (hitters), on teams with a scraped roster that season. Draft-eligible means past the junior year by roster class: Jr, Sr, Gr, or redshirt sophomore and up. Sophomores who were eligible by age are covered by the sensitivity check above. Roster class is matched by exact name, then by a nickname-tolerant key. Players with no matched class are left out whether drafted or not.
- **Stats.** Dashboard definitions (`vault_data/warehouse.py`). Opponent-adjusted run value is each PA's run value minus the opponent's long-weighted strength, per 100 PA. Percentiles are against qualified players in the same conference or division that season.
- **Conference strength.** Ridge fit of run value per PA on offense plus run prevention, one row per team-game side, all NCAA divisions in a single fit per season. Long-weighted with a three-year half-life, weighted by PA. Season-specific membership from 2024 (TrackMan league labels); fixed reference otherwise.
- **Player finder.** `overperformers/`, run once per season. A player passes a stat when his z-score against his conference and handedness group clears his tier's bar (power -0.75, D1 mid -0.55). He is an overperformer when he passes 70% or more of stats with a weighted composite of zero or better. Non-conference games are weighted by the opponent's tier.
- **Draft.** MLB StatsAPI, all rounds 2021-2026. For the high-school analysis, every pick 2015-2025 with school, home and birth state (`hs_draft.py`); school level inferred from the school name where the feed leaves it blank (2015-2017, 2019). Earlier high-school and JUCO picks are matched to college players by nickname-tolerant name key and home state, checked against MLB ids and a shuffled-state run.
- **Rosters.** Season archive pages for 2021-2026, with Internet Archive copies where a school keeps none. Each D1 roster must contain at least half of the players TrackMan saw for that team that season, and must not fit a neighbouring season clearly better. That check caught Clemson's archive labelling rosters by fall year, fall-2026 pages standing in for spring 2026, five schools whose websites were mislisted, and two table layouts that were being misread. Team-seasons whose roster fails the check are left out.
- **Draft link.** Picks are joined to player-seasons on the TrackMan IDs stored with each link. A school-name match is required, and a pick whose school has a distinguishing word the team lacks ("Utah Valley", "Cal Poly") is not linked to the flagship. Draft value is a pick score, ln((picks that year + 1) / overall pick), so rounds 11-20 count and the last pick scores above zero.
- **Limits.** Strength across divisions isn't measured reliably (fewer than 20 D1-vs-non-D1 games a season), which is why moves up from JUCO and D2 aren't scored. The ridge penalty is negligible at these sample sizes, so team strength is effectively a weighted least-squares fit. Long weighting uses every season back to 2021, but TrackMan coverage before 2023 is thin, so in practice most teams' strength rests on 2023 onward. Conference labels miss a couple of small moves (Mount St. Mary's, Washington State's Mountain West baseball home), and the 2025-26 "Pac-12" is two teams. The groups that moved up and got worse are small. Every result is an association, not an effect.